

- RAG Learning

3.4 Language and Power (Paper 3 pathway)

Edexcel A-Level English Language (9EN0) — Paper 3 Investigating Language

Language and Power investigates how language enacts, reproduces and resists power. Key frameworks: **Fairclough's Critical Discourse Analysis (CDA)**, **Brown & Levinson's politeness / face**, **Sinclair & Coulthard's IRF** for institutional discourse, **Goffman** on face-work, and **van Dijk** on elite discourse.

3.4.1 Fairclough — Instrumental vs Influential Power

Norman Fairclough distinguishes two categories of power:

- **Instrumental power** — exerted through direct authority: law, government, institutions. Features: imperatives, modals of obligation ("must", "shall"), formal archaic lexis, third-person impersonal. Example: court summons.
- **Influential power** — exerted through persuasion: advertising, journalism, political rhetoric. Features: rhetorical questions, inclusive "we", emotive lexis, direct address. Example: political speech.

3.4.2 Fairclough's Three-Dimensional Model of Discourse

Every discourse event has three dimensions:

1. **Text** — the specific linguistic choices made (lexis, grammar, graphology).
2. **Discursive practice** — production and reception: who made the text, how, and how it's consumed.
3. **Social practice** — the broader ideological and institutional context.

Analysis that only stays at the TEXT level misses the ideology. CDA moves across all three.

3.4.3 Synthetic Personalisation

Fairclough's term for the use of intimate/inclusive language by powerful producers to construct a simulated personal relationship with a mass audience. Examples:

- A supermarket email: "Hi Tom — we've saved your favourites for you".
- A political speech using inclusive "we".
- An advert using first-name brand voice + direct address.

Manufactures intimacy that doesn't really exist. Top-band analysis notices and critiques this.

3.4.4 Brown & Levinson — Politeness and Face

Every speaker has two aspects of **face** (public self-image):

- **Positive face** — desire to be liked, approved of, included.
- **Negative face** — desire not to be imposed on, to have autonomy.

A **face-threatening act (FTA)** (request, criticism, refusal) risks one or both. Politeness strategies mitigate:

- **Positive politeness** — attending to positive face: compliments, inclusive "we", shared jokes.
- **Negative politeness** — attending to negative face: hedges, indirect requests, apologies, modal softening ("Could you possibly...").
- **Off-record** — hinting rather than asserting.

3.4.5 Sinclair & Coulthard — IRF Model

Classroom discourse typically follows **Initiation** → **Response** → **Feedback**. Teacher initiates ("What's the capital of France?"), pupil responds, teacher evaluates ("Good"). The teacher controls two of three turns — the grammatical structure enacts institutional power.

The same pattern appears in medical consultations, job interviews, police interrogations — wherever an institution encounters a layperson.

3.4.6 Features of "Powerful" and "Powerless" Speech

Powerful features	Powerless features
Imperatives	Hedges ("sort of")
Modals of obligation ("must", "should")	Tag questions
Declarative certainty	Rising intonation on declaratives
Direct address + second-person imperative	Polite forms, apologies
Nominalisation and abstraction	Filler words, false starts
Latinate lexis	Avoidance of strong lexis

Remember O'Barr & Atkins (1980): these features correlate with POWER status, not gender. Anyone of low status may use them.

3.4.7 Grammar as Power — Active, Passive, Nominalisation

Grammatical choices redistribute responsibility:

- "Police shot the protester" — active, agent foregrounded.
- "The protester was shot" — passive, agent demoted.
- "Shots were fired" — passive + no agent.
- "There was a shooting" — nominalisation turning process into event.

"Mistakes were made" is a classic power move: the passive + nominalisation acknowledges the event while hiding WHO made mistakes. Grammar is ideological, not merely stylistic.

3.4.8 Power in Institutional Discourse

Legal register

- Archaic Latinate lexis ("herewith", "forthwith", "aforementioned") maintaining historical precedent.
- Formal passives distancing the actor.
- Embedded clauses for precision.
- Gatekeeping register restricts lay access — instrumental power.

Courtroom language

- Turn-taking controlled by judge.
- Declarative questions with presupposition ("You were at the scene, weren't you?").
- Address terms encoding hierarchy ("Your Honour").

Medical consultations

- Doctor leads question-answer sequences.
- Jargon gatekeeping ("you have idiopathic hypertension").
- Interruption and topic control.

3.4.9 Power in Mass Media

Van Dijk argues elite discourses (politics, media) reproduce ideology through everyday lexical, grammatical and discursive choices — what he calls "discourse and dominance". Key moves:

- **Lexical choice** — "migrants" vs "invaders" encodes stance.
- **Presupposition** — "when will the government finally..." presupposes failure.
- **Topic selection** — what is reported as news.
- **Agenda-setting** — prolonged coverage shapes perceived importance.
- **Framing** — selecting an angle that positions the reader.

3.4.10 Silence, Interruption and Power

- **Silence** can indicate power (refusing to respond) OR powerlessness (being denied the floor).
- **Interruption** can be assertive dominance OR supportive overlap — context determines meaning.
- **Topic control** — deciding what is discussed — is a subtle power move.
- **Turn allocation** — who gets to speak, when, how long — is policed by institutional roles.

3.4.11 Euphemism and Political Language

Political discourse often uses euphemism to soften controversial actions:

- "Collateral damage" for civilian casualties.
- "Enhanced interrogation" for torture.
- "Downsizing" for redundancies.
- "Reforms" for cuts.

Orwell's essay "Politics and the English Language" (1946) famously critiqued this pattern — vague abstract language masks concrete action. A useful historical reference in a Paper 3 answer.

Applied Example: A political speech includes "We must act now. Together we will rebuild. Make no mistake — this is our moment." Analysis: modal obligation "must" (power claim); inclusive "we" (synthetic personalisation); triadic rhythm (rhetorical force); imperatives "make no mistake" (direct address). Fairclough's influential power is enacted across lexis + grammar + pragmatics. Cite Brown & Levinson: inclusive "we" manages positive face of the audience; imperatives are softened by rhythmic delivery.

3.4.12 How to Analyse a Power Text

1. Identify whether the text operates through **instrumental** or **influential** power (or both).
2. Apply **Fairclough's three-dimensional model** (text, discursive practice, social practice).
3. Identify specific features at **multiple linguistic levels** — lexis, grammar, graphology, pragmatics.

4. Apply **Brown & Levinson's face** framework where relevant.
5. Apply **Sinclair & Coulthard** for institutional / classroom discourse.
6. Consider **silence, interruption, topic control**.
7. Evaluate the **ideology** the text encodes and how it positions the reader.

Paper 3 Tip: Powerful language is NOT always formal and Latinate. Informal "synthetic personalisation" is equally a power move. Consider silence, topic control, interruption, graphological foregrounding — power is enacted across many channels. Top-band Paper 3 answers integrate Fairclough, Brown & Levinson, Sinclair & Coulthard and van Dijk.

Key Terms Checklist

Instrumental / influential power (Fairclough), synthetic personalisation, face (positive/negative), FTA, politeness strategies, IRF (Sinclair & Coulthard), nominalisation, passive voice, modality (obligation / possibility), imperative, euphemism, gatekeeping, framing, agenda-setting, CDA (Critical Discourse Analysis), turn-taking, topic control. Theorists: **Fairclough, Brown & Levinson, Sinclair & Coulthard, Goffman, van Dijk, Orwell (historical).**